

YOUR SEASONAL HOMEOWNER HANDOUT

Fall home maintenance checklist

18 practical checks for Northeast Ohio houses and condos.

Start before the first forecast freeze; do not wait for snow. ^[10]

Condo owner? Confirm the scope first. Review your declaration and rules with the manager. Roofs, gutters, landscaping and shared systems may be association work; unit equipment may be yours. Get required approval before exterior or common-area work. Report problems and confirm completion rather than assuming they are covered. ^[9]

01 / Start outside

Check when done · write N/A where not applicable

- ☐ **01 Gutters & downspouts** **BEFORE FREEZE**
Clear leaves now and recheck after leaf drop. Confirm water flows away from the foundation and walking surfaces. Use an insured pro for ladder work or hard-to-reach gutters. ^[1]
- ☐ **02 Roof & flashing** **BOOK A PRO**
From the ground, look for missing shingles, sagging gutters or new ceiling stains. Have a roofer inspect flashing and repair leaks; do not climb onto the roof. ^[1]
- ☐ **03 Hoses & outdoor faucets** **BEFORE FREEZE**
Disconnect, drain and store hoses. Where a dedicated indoor shutoff exists, close it and drain the outdoor line per its instructions. Disconnect hoses even from frost-free faucets. ^[2]
- ☐ **04 Irrigation & outdoor water lines** **BEFORE FREEZE**
Arrange system-specific winterization before freezing weather. Have a qualified irrigation contractor handle any compressed-air blowout; do not guess pressure settings. ^[2]
- ☐ **05 Garden beds** **THIS FALL**
Pull weeds and remove diseased plant debris. Protect bare soil with suitable mulch; keep it off trunks and stems. Leave healthy seed heads and stems where practical for wildlife. ^[3]
- ☐ **06 Lawn & fallen leaves** **AFTER LEAF DROP**
Mulch light, dry leaf cover with the mower; collect heavy mats so grass stays visible. Clear wet leaves from walks and storm-drain openings without entering the street. ^[1, 3]
- ☐ **07 Trees & large limbs** **BOOK A PRO**
Look from the ground for dead, split or hanging limbs near the house. Hire an insured arborist for large branches; call the utility for limbs near power lines. ^[1]

HEAT, WATER & THE BUILDING SHELL

Get ahead of the first cold night.

Book service early. Use your equipment manuals for model-specific steps.

- ☐ **08 Fall furnace or heat-pump service** **BOOK NOW**
- Book a qualified HVAC technician before heating season. Ask for safety controls, combustion/heat exchanger checks where applicable, venting and condensate drainage review. Gas, electrical and refrigerant work are not DIY. ^[4]
- ☐ **09 Air filter & registers** **NOW + MONTHLY**
- Check the filter monthly; clean or replace per the manual using the approved size and rating. Follow safe shutdown instructions. Vacuum registers and keep returns clear of furniture. ^[4]
- ☐ **10 AC service & winterization** **BEFORE WINTER**
- Ask your HVAC pro to address cooling issues and follow your model's winterization instructions. Clear loose debris; do not wrap the entire condenser. Keep a heat pump uncovered and available for winter use. Do not test cooling in cold weather unless the manual allows it. ^[4, 5]
- ☐ **11 Thermostat & freeze-prone pipes** **BEFORE FREEZE**
- Test heat and replace thermostat batteries if needed. Insulate accessible pipes in unheated areas. When away, leave heat on at least 55°F, or higher if your building or insurer requires; arrange home checks. ^[2, 4]
- ☐ **12 Windows, doors & drafts** **BEFORE FREEZE**
- Check weatherstripping and door sweeps; seal suitable gaps with the right caulk. Keep drainage holes and required ventilation open. Ask a pro about attic air leaks rather than covering vents. ^[1, 5]
- ☐ **13 Sump pump & discharge** **BEFORE WET WEATHER**
- If installed, test per the manual with water and confirm it pumps out. Check the backup battery/alarm and keep discharge clear. Call a plumber if it fails; do not open a sealed radon sump cover. ^[6]

LIAM'S #1 HVAC RECOMMENDATION

Tell him Liam sent you!

Corey Killian

Killian Heating and Cooling

412-216-5255

Liam's personal recommendation, not independent vetting. Confirm Northeast Ohio service area, availability, insurance and any required licensing directly before booking.

Stop and call for help: If you smell gas or a CO alarm sounds, get everyone outside and call 911 or the gas utility from a safe location. Do not troubleshoot the equipment yourself.

Service booked for: _____ Follow-up: _____

SAFETY & THE FINAL WALK-THROUGH

Finish the small jobs now.

Check these before heating season or the first snow, as noted.

- ☐ **14 Smoke & carbon monoxide alarms** DO NOW
Use test buttons now and monthly. Replace batteries as directed, smoke alarms at 10 years, and CO alarms at their stated end of life. Confirm smoke coverage in bedrooms, outside sleeping areas and on every level. ^[7]
- ☐ **15 Fireplace & chimney** BEFORE FIRST FIRE
Schedule an inspection before the first fire and cleaning if needed. Have damaged flues or gas fireplace issues professionally serviced. Keep combustibles away and review your household escape plan. ^[1, 5]
- ☐ **16 Dryer exhaust** THIS FALL
Clean the lint filter each load. Check for a crushed duct and an outside flap that opens during use. Arrange vent cleaning if airflow is weak or drying takes longer; use a pro for concealed or shared ducts. ^[8]
- ☐ **17 Steps, handrails & outdoor lighting** BEFORE SNOW
Check loose rails, uneven walking surfaces and failed entry lights. Arrange safe repairs before ice arrives. Set out a shovel and surface-compatible ice melt; confirm who clears condo walks. ^[1]
- ☐ **18 Patio, balcony & seasonal equipment** BEFORE SNOW
Secure or store furniture and drain planters that could crack. Prepare the mower for storage and snow equipment for use per their manuals. Keep exit routes clear; follow association storage rules. ^[1]

Sources & further reading

[1] State Farm · Fall home maintenance
statefarm.com

[3] UMN Extension · Garden beds / leaf mulch
extension.umn.edu

[5] Trane · Winter HVAC preparation
trane.com

[7] U.S. Fire Administration · Smoke / CO alarms
usfa.fema.gov

[9] Ohio law · Condo board responsibilities
codes.ohio.gov

[2] American Red Cross · Frozen pipes
redcross.org

[4] ENERGY STAR · HVAC maintenance
energystar.gov

[6] NDSU Extension · Sump-pump checks
ag.ndsu.edu

[8] U.S. Fire Administration · Dryer safety
usfa.fema.gov

[10] NWS Cleveland · Frost / freeze information
weather.gov/cle

Additional guidance: [UMN leaf mulching](#) · [USFA monthly CO-alarm testing](#). Source titles are clickable in the digital PDF.

General maintenance guidance, not an inspection or repair specification. Follow manufacturer instructions, local requirements and association documents. Use qualified, insured professionals for roof/ladder work, combustion, wiring and other hazardous tasks. Skip jobs you cannot safely reach or perform.

Still to schedule: _____